

MUKESH BHANDARI

57, FURNACE MANUFACTURER
CMD. ELECTROTHERM GROUP
TURNOVER IN 2003 Rs 32 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 2,000 crore

WEALTH INDUCTION

In India's steel-making industry he is the man with the golden touch, thanks to the grip that Mukesh Bhandari's Electrotherm has established in the induction furnace making business. The fact that 15 million tonnes of the total 60 million tonnes of steel manufactured in India today is produced through the furnaces made by Electrotherm speaks volumes of the company's hold over the steel market.

In the mid-'80s, armed with a degree in electrical engineering from Shri Govindram Sakseria Institute of Technology and Science, Indore, and his experience as a service engineer for induction furnaces, Bhandari used to take his scooter around Ahmedabad, repairing ONGC drilling rigs and furnaces. He saw that the blast furnace technology couldn't use scrapped steel for manufacturing stainless steel. On the other hand, the electric arc furnace technol-

ogy which could use scrap steel for this purpose was very expensive. He realised that the only way to produce cheap stainless steel was to manufacture it from scrapped steel with the help of small, low-cost induction furnaces. In 1983, with the princely sum of Rs 18,000 that he received from ONGC for successfully fixing a serious technical snag in a rig, he launched Electrotherm. Two years later he designed the first small induction furnace of just five tonnes. Gradually, the capacity of the furnaces he produced increased—from 5 tonnes it became 15 tonnes. Today, Electrotherm is the only company in the world to manufacture a 30-tonne induction furnace.

Innovation remains the bedrock of Electrotherm's growth. Bhandari has set up a 30-MW eco-friendly power plant in Electrotherm's steel making unit in Kutch which uses waste gases to generate power. The exhaust gases which are expelled in the air while making sponge iron are harnessed here by passing them through a waste heat boiler to make steam which in turn generates power. Says Bhandari, "R&D based on innovation is our biggest strength. My motto is never to allow anything to go waste." And he

derives his strength from his role model Ram Narayana, who taught electronics at Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore. "He made challenges appear so easy," he says.

SUCCESS MANTRA

If you are determined and diligent, you need not be very intelligent.

biggest BENEFIT

His company has generated six lakh jobs in the last 10 years.

unusual CLIENTS

One is former Pakistani PM Nawaz Sharif's company Hillmetals.

If things go well, Bhandari may soon lend his Midas touch to the power-operated two-wheeler industry. Electrotherm has already sold 60,000 battery-operated Yo Bykes worth Rs 80 crore in the past 18 months. "There are many alternative ways to make power but none to make petrol or diesel. We are working on a strategy which will help the Yo Byke revolutionise the individual transport industry," he says, adding that the immediate goal is to increase the bike's speed from 45 kmph to 60 kmph. Clearly, the man is ready to zoom ahead of time.

by Uday Mahurkar



SHAILASH RAVAL